Playing against Brian Lara

With five years of experience, I was now firmly established in the Indian team and people had started comparing me with other players on the international scene at the time. The press love to set up rivalries and with a home series against the West Indies coming up at the end of 1994, it was inevitable that the fans and the media would pit me against Brian Lara.

Without doubt Brian Lara is one of the best players to have played this sport. I first met Brian in November 1990 during a festival match in Toronto between the West Indies and a World XI, which was played at the SkyDome, a stadium designed for Major League Baseball. We got along straight away and I enjoyed talking to him and listening to his insights. He was a clear thinker and had an excellent grasp of the nuances of the game. To add to his unrivalled flamboyance, he also had great hands and footwork, making him a champion batsman of our time. Brian was capable of playing a number of shots to the same delivery and his ability to adjust at the last moment set him apart. His technique wasn't orthodox but that had never mattered to him. He more than made up for it with skill and footwork.

By the time the West Indies came to India in November–December 1994, Brian was already the premier batsman of his team. We knew we had to stop Brian from scoring to have a chance in the Test series, but it was easier said than done, and Brian played a very important role for the West Indies in the third and final Test at Mohali. It was his innings of 91 that set the platform for a series-levelling West Indies win. For the visitors, Jimmy Adams too played a crucial part, with 252 runs in the match.

I had a pretty good series and in the first match at Mumbai I was pleased with my performance in the second innings, scoring 85 after coming in to bat at a precarious 11–3. We won the match by 96 runs, having managed to get Brian out early in both innings. In the second Test at the VCA stadium in Nagpur, I scored 179 in our first innings. I remember this innings for my wild celebrations after scoring the century, something I hardly ever did in my career. In fact, it was an aberration, caused by a combination of factors. I was not out on 81 overnight and started the second day against the second new ball. I hit Kenneth Benjamin for four fours in the first few overs and raced to 97 in no time.